

DIP OF THE HORIZON

screenplay by
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*“The true essence of these subjects
consists precisely in going in each matter
beyond what is necessary.”*

– al-Biruni, *India*, vol. I, p. 22, Sachau translation

ACT ONE

FADE IN:

EXT. MOUNTAINSIDE - PRE-DAWN

Cold. Still. Stars fading out of a graying sky.

AL-BIRUNI (40s, spare build, exact and unhurried in his movements) climbs the last stretch of the slope alone, carrying a wooden instrument case.

A YOUNG SHEPHERD (14), already up with his flock, watches him from a distance. Not wary. Curious, in the way of someone who has seen this before and still doesn't understand it.

Biruni finds his spot. Sets up a homemade quadrant on a modified tripod, working from memory rather than instruction. He is not hurrying, though the light is changing fast.

He sights along the instrument toward the horizon. Marks something on a wax tablet with a stylus. Waits. Sights again.

The Shepherd drifts closer, unable to help himself.

SHEPHERD

What are you looking for?

BIRUNI

(not looking up)

Nothing. I'm measuring what's already there.

He crouches, does not show the boy the instrument's face. Instead he works arithmetic into the dirt with a stick – an angle, a known height, a formula worked through by feel.

SHEPHERD

Measuring what.

BIRUNI

How big the thing is that we're both standing on.

The boy looks down at the mountain under his own feet. Then out at the horizon. He is plainly unconvinced that lines scratched in dirt could know something his eyes can't.

He doesn't argue the point. He just turns back toward his flock.

Biruni looks at the number in the dirt for a long moment – no triumph in it, just a private, settled satisfaction. He packs the quadrant away.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSERVATORY WORKSHOP, KHWAREZM - DAY

Cramped, well-used. Astrolabes in various states of construction hang from the walls and lie across worktables. Biruni works beside two APPRENTICES on a half-finished astrolabe, running a finger along its rete, feeling for error before the numbers confirm it.

BIRUNI

This star's arm is wrong.

APPRENTICE 1

It matches the tables we copied.

BIRUNI

Then the tables we copied are wrong.

(beat)

Copying isn't the same as checking.

He recalculates on the spot, quick and assured – the ease of a man for whom this kind of work costs him nothing.

Elsewhere in the workshop: two small stones, alike enough in color and cut that APPRENTICE 2 has set them together as a matched pair. Biruni suspends each in turn from a small balance, weighing it dry, then submerged.

APPRENTICE 2

They're the same stone. Same seller, same day.

BIRUNI

They're the same color. That's not the same thing.

He notes both figures without ceremony and sets the stones down in two different trays. He doesn't explain further – doesn't need to. The eye was never going to settle this; the balance already has.

The COURT ASTROLOGER (50s, unhurried, comfortable in every room he enters) drifts in, glancing over the shop with the easy familiarity of someone who's never once doubted his own usefulness here.

ASTROLOGER

The stars are generous today.

(beat)

Or they will be, once I've finished with them.

BIRUNI

The stars don't need your help.

ASTROLOGER

(not unkindly)

No. But the ruler does.

Biruni doesn't dignify it with a response. The Astrologer doesn't need one – he wasn't really asking.

CUT TO:

EXT. KHWAREZM, CITY STREET - DAY

Ordinary life. A market. A canal catching the light. The observatory's dome visible above the rooftops in the background – unremarkable, everyday, the way a thing looks right before you learn you're about to lose it.

CUT TO:

INT. BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Biruni at a low table, notebooks fanned around him in careful disorder. Among ordinary astronomical notes, he lifts out a small clay tablet – Sanskrit characters, copied years earlier from a merchant's ledger.

He can't read it. He's kept it anyway.

Beside it, a page of his own guesses at a few of the characters – visibly revised more than once, crossed out, re-annotated in a different ink. He looks at the page for a while. Doesn't write anything new tonight. Sets it aside, carefully, like something left open on purpose.

CUT TO:

INT. BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

He pulls out a different set of pages: a running correspondence, both hands visible on the paper – his own, and a second, unfamiliar hand copied in alongside it. A letter from

IBN SINA, arrived by courier some weeks before, still being answered.

The exchange is civil and entirely uncompromising. Ibn Sina argues the universe has no beginning, following the philosophers Biruni has read and half-admires. Biruni is not persuaded, and doesn't pretend to be for the sake of the friendship.

He writes his reply in the same unhurried hand he uses for star positions – no more heat in the argument than in an eclipse table, and no less conviction.

We don't need the whole letter. Just enough, glimpsed on the page, to see him accuse a man he respects of borrowing an authority – Aristotle's – instead of checking the claim itself.

He seals it. Sets it with the outgoing post. No sense that either man expects to convince the other. That was never quite the point of writing.

CUT TO:

EXT. KHWAREZM, OBSERVATORY COURTYARD - DAY

Smoke on the horizon, thin at first. A sound underneath the ordinary noise of the courtyard – distant, wrong. A horn.

People start moving with purpose. The Astrologer crosses the courtyard at a near-run, all his earlier ease gone.

ASTROLOGER

Ghazni's army. They're not stopping at the gates.

Biruni doesn't run toward shelter. He runs for the workshop.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSERVATORY WORKSHOP - CONTINUOUS

Chaos outside; inside, Biruni is eerily, terribly focused. Saddlebags – clearly not enough room for everything the room holds. He has to choose.

He takes: the portable astrolabe. The notebooks. The clay tablet.

He has to leave: a larger instrument, one we recognize from earlier in the scene – one of the astrolabes he was correcting with the apprentices. He touches its edge once. Leaves it.

GHAZNAVID SOLDIERS enter – not gratuitous, but clearly here to take inventory of a place, not to ask permission. An OFFICER looks over the workshop the way you'd appraise livestock.

OFFICER

You're the instrument-maker.

BIRUNI

I'm an astronomer.

OFFICER

(already turning away)

You're coming with the instruments.

CUT TO:

EXT. ROAD TO GHAZNI - DAY

A displaced column moves under guard – scholars, craftsmen, crated goods. Not quite prisoners. Not remotely free.

Biruni walks near the rear, notebook open even while walking, sketching a star position from memory. Correcting a figure without breaking stride. The work does not stop. Only where it happens has changed.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI COURT, ANTECHAMBER - DAY

Biruni waits in a line of requisitioned scholars and craftsmen – a mixed, uneasy group. A CHAMBERLAIN moves down the line assigning roles with the flat efficiency of a man taking inventory.

CHAMBERLAIN

(not looking up)

Instruments and tables. You'll work under the court astronomer.

BIRUNI

I'd like to request something else.

The Chamberlain looks up. This doesn't happen.

CHAMBERLAIN

Go on.

BIRUNI

When the campaign goes into India – I want to go. Not with the army. Ahead of it, or beside it. It doesn't matter which. I want to learn the language. Not through translators. Myself.

CHAMBERLAIN

Why would you want that.

BIRUNI

Because a number translated by someone else isn't the same number. I want the number itself.

The Chamberlain doesn't understand this. Doesn't pretend to. But it's strange enough that he's not willing to decide it on his own authority.

CHAMBERLAIN

That's not mine to grant.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI COURT, AUDIENCE HALL - DAY

Biruni stands before MAHMUD OF GHAZNI – not a monster, not a caricature. A man who has spent his life evaluating what things are for.

MAHMUD

You're the one who wants to learn their language before we've finished taking their cities.

BIRUNI

Yes.

MAHMUD

Most men want the gold first.

BIRUNI

I don't have a use for gold I can't check.

Mahmud studies him. This isn't admiration exactly – more like the mild interest of a man who's found an odd tool that might still turn out to be useful.

MAHMUD

Go, then. Learn what you like. Bring back whatever's useful.

BIRUNI

I intend to bring back what's true. Whether or not it's useful is your problem, not mine.

A beat. Mahmud doesn't react much either way – he's already moving his attention to the next matter in the room, which is itself the point. To power, this whole exchange is a rounding error.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI COURT, ANTECHAMBER - LATER

A CLERK enters Biruni's name into a register, unhurried, mid-list. He reads the entry back before Biruni can stop him.

CLERK

Al-Biruni. Court astrologer.

BIRUNI

Astronomer.

CLERK

(already writing)

The register doesn't have a column for the difference.

Biruni looks at the word on the page a moment – the same title, more or less, the man drifting the workshop back in Khwarezm wore without embarrassment. He doesn't ask the Clerk to change it. There's no one here it would matter to.

He picks up the pen himself, adds nothing, changes nothing. Sets it back down. The title stands, uncorrected, exactly as wrong as it will remain for as long as he works under it.

CUT TO:

EXT. GHAZNI, CITY GATE - DAY

Biruni joins a column heading toward the Indus – traveling in the protection of Mahmud's army, but toward a different purpose than the soldiers around him.

He carries the same saddlebags from the workshop. Takes out the clay tablet once. Looks at it. Puts it away.

WIDE SHOT: the column moving out, into terrain none of them have mapped the way Biruni means to map it.

HARD CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

FADE IN:

EXT. INDUS FRONTIER, ENCAMPMENT - DAY

Biruni separates from the main column. His escort is thin, provisional – he is tolerated here, not protected.

First sight of Indian territory: a river valley, not a horizon-at-height composition – deliberately different framing from the mountain that opened the film.

In the middle distance, a figure – PANDIT, an ASTRONOMER-PRIEST – works alone with an instrument Biruni doesn't recognize. Biruni watches for a long moment before approaching.

CUT TO:

EXT. OBSERVATORY SITE, RIVER VALLEY - DAY

Biruni approaches on foot, alone, hands visible, no escort in frame. Pandit watches him come with open wariness – every reason to distrust anyone arriving behind Mahmud's army, and he doesn't hide it.

Biruni doesn't attempt charm. He sets down his own saddlebags, unpacks his quadrant, and takes a reading in full view – silent, procedural, exactly as he did alone on the mountain in the film's opening.

Pandit watches the whole sequence without moving.

PANDIT

(finally, testing)

You're measuring the same thing
we measure.

BIRUNI

I don't know yet. That's why I'm
here.

A long beat. Pandit doesn't warm to this. But he doesn't
walk away either.

CUT TO:

INT./EXT. OBSERVATORY, WORKING SESSION - DAY

Biruni and Pandit, working the same eclipse prediction in
parallel, each on his own instrument, in his own notation.
Neither explains his method to the other. Neither can read
the other's page.

They finish within moments of each other. Compare results –
not the working, just the final numbers.

The numbers agree.

Neither man says anything for a moment. It isn't triumph.
It's closer to recognition – two people who have just
learned, without yet being able to say why, that they are
doing the same thing.

Biruni's notebook page, glimpsed close: the layout delib-
erately echoes the astrolabe-correction pages from Khwarezm
– same hand, same habits, now describing an instrument he'd
never seen a month ago.

CUT TO:

EXT. NANDANA FORT, SALT RANGE - DAY

A different kind of height than the film has shown before
– not a single peak but a fort on a ridge, the Salt Range
folding away below it toward a hazy plain. Biruni arrives
with a length of knotted cord, a portable quadrant, and Pan-
dit, curious enough this time to follow without being asked.

Biruni paces out a fixed distance along level ground below the ridge, driving a marker at each end. From the first marker, he sights the fort's high point with the quadrant and notes the angle. He walks to the second marker – the whole distance between them measured, exact, deliberate – and sights the same point again.

PANDIT

Two angles. One height.

BIRUNI

Two angles and the distance between them. The height falls out of the difference. I don't need to climb anything yet to know how tall it is.

He works the figure into a wax tablet, quick, assured. Then he climbs, the same unhurried economy of motion from the film's opening. At the top, he doesn't sight the horizon directly – he levels a plumb line first, then measures the small angle between that true horizontal and the horizon itself.

PANDIT

(watching the plumb line,
not the horizon)
Why does the horizon need measuring at all. It's just where the land stops.

BIRUNI

Because it doesn't stop where it looks like it stops. From up here it dips below level, and how far it dips depends on nothing but the size of the thing we're standing on. The height I already have. The dip gives me the rest.

He sets the two figures against each other on the tablet – the fort's height from the first measurement, the dip an-

gle from the second – and works through the triangle they form. No showmanship in it. The same posture as a man doing arithmetic in dirt at dawn, just with more zeroes.

He arrives at a number. Sits with it a moment, testing it against itself rather than presenting it to Pandit.

PANDIT

That's the answer, or a step toward one.

BIRUNI

It's the size of the earth. Or close enough to it that being wrong would have to be interesting.

Pandit looks out at the plain, then back at the tablet, visibly recalibrating what the last hour was actually for.

PANDIT

You did this from one hilltop. No baseline between cities. No second observer a thousand miles away.

BIRUNI

I didn't have a thousand miles to spend. I had a rope, a ridge, and an afternoon.

He packs the quadrant away with the same care as always. No triumph in his face – the private, settled look of a man filing a fact rather than winning an argument. Pandit watches him do it, something shifting slightly in how he watches.

CUT TO:

INT. PANDIT'S HOUSE / STUDY - DAY

Lighter register. Biruni, trying to arrange a second meeting, runs headlong into four incompatible ways of naming "when." A servant gives one date. Pandit's assistant gives another. A third figure, consulted for confirmation, gives a third.

BIRUNI

I am trying to determine a single day. I now have four.

PANDIT

(not quite hiding his amusement)
You have four systems. The day is the same day.

BIRUNI

Then the day is easy. The systems are the problem.

He sits, and – visibly delighted rather than frustrated – starts building a conversion table on the spot, cross-referencing all four. Pandit watches this happen with something close to affection he isn't ready to admit to yet.

CUT TO:

EXT. RIVERBANK - DAY

Brief. Biruni and Pandit walking. The calendar problem leads naturally into the deeper one underneath it.

PANDIT

Your calendar assumes time runs in one direction and ends somewhere.

BIRUNI

Doesn't yours?

PANDIT

Not always. Not in every system I could show you.

He doesn't explain further here. Lets it sit as an open door.

CUT TO:

INT. STUDY - DAY

The central scene of the act.

Biruni has been working through a term – PRAMĀṆA – that keeps appearing in Pandit's explanations of how a claim becomes knowledge rather than mere assertion. He proposes an Arabic gloss for it, something in the region of "proof" or "evidence."

BIRUNI

If I write it as "proof" –

PANDIT

Then you've written a court document. Not what I mean.

BIRUNI

"A means of valid knowledge," then. Closer?

PANDIT

Closer. Still not it. Your word already has a job. It works for a judge, weighing one claim against another after the fact. Mine works before that – it's what lets a claim be the kind of thing

that could be weighed at all.

BIRUNI

Then it isn't a word. It's a category.

PANDIT

It's several categories, and how many of them count depends who you ask inside my own tradition. Perception counts. Inference counts. Some schools count testimony. Some don't. You're not translating a word. You're translating an argument that hasn't finished happening.

Biruni sits with this. Doesn't immediately write anything. This is new – earlier in the film, the instinct to resolve into a clean note would have been immediate.

BIRUNI

Then I won't translate it.

PANDIT

You have to write something.

BIRUNI

I'll write what it isn't. And why.

He picks up the stylus. On the notebook page – held on camera – he does not write a translated term. He writes, instead, a description of the gap itself: what "proof" captures, what it misses, why no single Arabic word can hold both.

This is the notebook's first entry of this kind in the film: not a record of an equivalence, but a record of a failure to find one, made precise enough to be useful anyway.

CUT TO:

INT. STUDY - NIGHT

Biruni alone, re-reading the page from the day. Old habit surfaces – he begins, almost without noticing, to compress his own note back down into something cleaner, more citable.

He stops. Reads what he's just written. Crosses it out. Returns to the longer, harder version.

No dialogue. The correction is the whole scene.

CUT TO:

EXT. NANDANA FORT, SALT RANGE - DAWN

A limestone hill rises above the Punjab plain. The ruined walls of NANDANA FORT hold the ridge. Below them, on a rare stretch of level ground, Biruni and Pandit drive a measuring stake into the earth.

This is not the solitary mountain image from the opening. There are assistants, rope, marked rods, a plumb line, instruments laid out in order. The problem has become larger, and so has the procedure.

Biruni sights the summit through an instrument from the first station. Pandit records the angle. An assistant carries a marker along the level ground until the measured rope is fully extended.

PANDIT

You could climb it and measure
from above.

BIRUNI

Not until I know how high above
us "above" is.

At the second station Biruni takes another sighting. Two angles. One known distance between them.

In the dust, he draws two narrow triangles sharing the same vertical side. Pandit sees the construction before Biruni

finishes it. He writes.

The unknown height resolves from the baseline and the difference between the two sight lines. Biruni checks the arithmetic, then checks it again by reversing the stations.

PANDIT

The hill first.

BIRUNI

Then the Earth.

CUT TO:

EXT. NANDANA HILLSIDE - LATER

The climb is long and inelegant. Instruments wrapped against dust. The plumb bob knocks against Biruni's knee. Below them, the two ground stations diminish into points whose separation still matters.

Halfway up, Pandit looks back toward the plain. From here the horizon appears obvious, almost uselessly so. Biruni does not look yet. He keeps climbing.

CUT TO:

EXT. NANDANA SUMMIT - LATE AFTERNOON

The Punjab plain extends westward under a clear sky. Biruni sets the instrument at the measured summit point. Beside it, a plumb line establishes the vertical with indifferent precision.

He levels his sight, then lowers it until the horizon enters the line. The angle is slight – the dip between a true horizontal and the visible edge of the world.

PANDIT

That's all?

BIRUNI

That's the only part the Earth
gives us directly.

Biruni reads the arc. Pandit reads it independently. They
exchange values. Agreement.

On the page: the hill's height from the two ground stations;
the dip angle from the summit; a right triangle whose long
side runs from the Earth's center to Nandana. The radius is
the remaining unknown.

The calculation proceeds in fragments as the light changes.
Biruni rejects one line, repeats the division, and arrives
at the same figure. Pandit checks the last operation without
being asked.

The result, converted into modern measure: roughly 6,339
kilometers. Within about one percent of the value accepted
now. No one in the scene knows either comparison.

Biruni looks toward the horizon – not awed, exactly. Measur-
ing whether the number and the world can continue to occupy
the same thought.

PANDIT

You measured the Earth without
crossing it.

BIRUNI

I measured one hill. The rest is
inference.

Pandit considers this distinction. Then takes the page and
checks the number once more.

CUT TO:

EXT. RUINED OBSERVATORY/LIBRARY SITE - DAY

Biruni and Pandit arrive at a site recently destroyed –
Mahmud's forces, not long past. Instruments smashed. Texts
burned or scattered. The specific, itemized loss of things
that cannot be rebuilt from memory.

Shot with restraint. No spectacle. Just the wreckage, walked through slowly.

PANDIT

(hard, not performed)

Tell me what any of it is worth.
The listening. The careful word
you wouldn't write yesterday be-
cause it wasn't exact enough. Set
against this.

BIRUNI

(a long beat)

I don't know.

PANDIT

That's not good enough.

BIRUNI

I know.

No further exchange. Pandit walks the ruin alone. Biruni doesn't follow him into it. The scene ends without resolution – deliberately. Nothing later in the film should be allowed to fully answer this.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNAVID CAMP, TENT - DAY

A visiting CLERIC, aware of Biruni's work, wants it put to use.

CLERIC

You've spent a year learning
their errors in detail. Put that
detail to use.

BIRUNI

I've spent a year learning what they believe, and why, on terms they'd recognize as their own.

CLERIC

That's a strange thing to be proud of.

BIRUNI

If you want a refutation, you don't need me for that. Anyone can refute what they haven't understood. It's understanding it that takes the year.

The Cleric doesn't push further here – files it away rather than escalating. (Escalation is Act Three's job, not this scene's.)

CUT TO:

INT. STUDY - DAY

Pandit reads a draft passage of Biruni's. Stops. Reads it again.

PANDIT

This is closer to your own philosophers than to what I told you.

BIRUNI

(defensive, brief)

It's a translation. Something is always –

PANDIT

Not this much. Read it again.

Biruni reads it again. We watch him find the distortion himself, a beat late, the way you find a mistake you already half-knew was there. He picks up the stylus and begins revising, in front of us, without further argument.

This is 2.7's counterpart: the discipline he thought he'd internalized alone, shown to still need Pandit's eye. He hasn't arrived. He's still working.

CUT TO:

EXT. OBSERVATORY / STUDY, LATER - DAY

Word arrives – the campaign is concluding, or the political weather has shifted; either way, Biruni is recalled to Ghazni. Practical, unglamorous packing. The felt asymmetry of the exchange sits under everything: what Biruni gets to carry home, and what stays.

CUT TO:

EXT. RIVERBANK / OBSERVATORY THRESHOLD - DUSK

Restrained. Not sentimental.

Pandit hands Biruni a text – something Biruni can't fully use without further help, deliberately left incomplete rather than a tidy closing gift. In return, Biruni offers the clay tablet from Khwarezm – the one he's carried and annotated since before he could read a word of it.

Pandit turns it over once. Doesn't need it the way Biruni needed it. Takes it anyway, understanding the gesture for what it is.

PANDIT

You'll write this without me now.

BIRUNI

Badly, probably.

PANDIT

(not quite warmth, not
quite its absence)
Try not to make it clean.

Biruni nods. No further words. He turns and walks toward the
column re-forming behind him.

HARD CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

FADE IN:

INT. GHAZNI, BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - DAY

Biruni back among his own instruments. They read differently now – competence that used to cost him nothing now sits oddly against two years of effort. He unpacks the notebooks from India: the accumulated mess, the unresolved contradictions Pandit told him not to make clean.

He lays them out on the table in some rough order. Doesn't start writing yet. Just looks at the volume of it – crossed-out pages, marginal notes, the second kind of entry from the Pramāṇa scene sitting alongside ordinary translations.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI COURT, ANTECHAMBER - DAY

A COURT FIGURE greets Biruni with vague, uncomprehending warmth.

COURT FIGURE

They say you learned their whole religion.

BIRUNI

I learned a fraction of it. Carefully.

COURT FIGURE

(already moving on)

Good, good.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI, SHARED WORKSPACE - DAY

The COURT ASTROLOGER, older now, still doing exactly what he did in Act One – reading the instruments toward whatever answer is wanted. He and Biruni share the space without much conversation. The contrast needs no dialogue: the Astrologer unchanged and comfortable, Biruni visibly changed and visibly tired in a way that isn't about to go away.

CUT TO:

INT. CLERIC'S CHAMBER - DAY

The CLERIC from the Ghaznavid camp – or a superior standing in for him – requests to see the manuscript-in-progress. Direct pressure now.

CLERIC

Nobody is asking you to lie.

BIRUNI

No. You're asking me to leave out the parts that are true and inconvenient. That's a different kind of lying. Not a lesser one.

CLERIC

Consider carefully who reads this, once it's finished. And who decides what you're given to

finish it with.

He doesn't threaten outright. He doesn't need to. The implication – patronage, access, material support, all of it contingent – sits in the room without being named.

CUT TO:

INT. BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Writing. Not a triumphant montage – a laborious one.

Draft pages fill with cross-outs. The camera holds on the page in extreme close-up at intervals, echoing – deliberately, if a match-cut is achievable – the Sanskrit tablet notes from Khwarezm, then the Pramāṇa page from India, now the manuscript itself. Same hand. Same habit. Increasingly abstract objects.

At one point, Biruni writes a passage, reads it back, and stops – catching, a beat late, a place where something foreign has been smoothed into something too comfortably familiar. This time there is no one else in the room to catch it.

He crosses it out. Rewrites it harder – a beat longer, a beat more honest – without anyone watching him do it.

Later in the same night, working through material on traditions he encountered only by report rather than direct study, he writes a line acknowledging exactly that – that for some of what follows, he is relying on what he was told rather than what he verified himself. He underlines it, rather than smoothing it into the surrounding text as if it carried the same weight as his firsthand work.

CUT TO:

INT. GHAZNI COURT, AUDIENCE HALL - DAY

Biruni before MAHMUD again. Older. Same transactional register as their first exchange, though something in it has shifted with time rather than with any change in Mahmud himself.

MAHMUD

Two years, and what do I have.

BIRUNI

A book that won't tell you what
you already believe.

MAHMUD

(a beat – almost respect,
not quite)
That's not nothing. It's also not
much.

BIRUNI

It's what's true. I told you
that's what I'd bring back.

Mahmud doesn't stop him. Doesn't praise him either. Already turning his attention elsewhere – the same gesture from Act One, not warmed by two years, only repeated. That repetition is the point: the work's value was never going to depend on this room recognizing it.

CUT TO:

INT. BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

The preface.

Shot as close to one unbroken take as the scene allows. Biruni alone, writing. Both notebooks – India's, and the manuscript's own draft history – present in the room without being shown directly; their weight is in how he writes, not in cutaways to them.

He writes, in his own words (paraphrased here, not quoted verbatim from any historical text): that he intends to set down what the people of India hold to be true, in terms they would recognize as their own – neither defending it nor refuting it, only representing it as it stands.

He finishes the passage. Sets down the stylus. No one is in the room to witness this. No music swell, no triumphant

turn to camera. He looks at the page the way he looked at the number in the dirt on the mountain, at the start of the film: private, settled, no external validation attached to it or needed by it.

CUT TO:

INT./EXT. GHAZNI, VARIOUS - DAY

Brief coda. A SCRIBE copies the manuscript by hand – ordinary, unglamorous, ink and patience. No sense of the book's later importance; just the plain mechanics of how consequential work actually enters the world, one copied page at a time.

CUT TO:

EXT. GHAZNI COURT, TREASURY COURTYARD - DAY

Years further on. Mahmud is gone. The banners have changed; so has the room's whole register, quieter now, less certain of itself. MAS'UD (30s, his father's son, not his father's temperament) presides over a small ceremony – three camel-loads of silver, brought out in thanks for the astronomical canon Biruni has just finished and dedicated to him.

MAS'UD

My father collected instruments.
I'd rather be remembered for collecting what they were for.

Biruni looks at the silver for a long moment – not moved by it, not performing indifference either. Weighing it, plainly, the way he weighs anything.

BIRUNI

I have no use for it.

He has it returned to the treasury before he leaves the courtyard. Mas'ud watches him go – more curious than offended, the way you'd watch an instrument do something you hadn't accounted for.

CUT TO:

INT. BIRUNI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Older still. Biruni at his table, working now from proportion rather than direct observation – his own old figure for the earth's circumference, from the mountain and from Nandana, set against the known span of land connecting Europe, Africa, and Asia. By his own numbers, the known world accounts for less than half the surface there is.

He writes through the reasoning on the page, unhurried: whatever forces raised the land he has already measured would not plausibly have spared the remainder; somewhere in the unaccounted expanse, at latitudes a person could survive, there is very probably land no one in this room will ever see confirmed.

No instrument can settle this one. No journey either, not in what's left of his life. He sets it down anyway, in the same hand, the same discipline, as everything else in the manuscripts stacked around him.

He looks at the page. The same private, settled expression from the mountain at the very start of the film – except this time there is no ground underfoot to check the number against. Only the arithmetic, and his confidence in it.

CUT TO:

EXT. MOUNTAINSIDE - PRE-DAWN

The same location as the opening. The same stillness.

A figure climbs the last stretch of the slope, carrying an instrument case – NOT Biruni. Younger. We don't need to know exactly who; it could be the grown Shepherd from the opening, or simply someone new to whom the practice has passed. The film doesn't explain the substitution. It trusts the image.

The figure sets up a quadrant. Sights toward the horizon. Marks something down. The same gesture, exactly, that opened the film – except the man who taught it to no one in particular is nowhere in the frame.

The horizon hasn't moved.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT THREE. END OF SCREENPLAY.

END OF ACT THREE

END OF SCREENPLAY